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# Randy Sandke

*Randy Sandke was born in Chicago in 1949 and was introduced to jazz by his trumpet playing older brother. After a ten year period where he concentrated on guitar, Randy returned to the trumpet and established himself in the New York City jazz scene of the 1970s. He has become one of the most in-demand trumpeters working today, appearing with Jon Hendricks, Benny Carter, Kenny Davern, Mel Torme and many others. He has recorded frequently, often searching out obscure tunes to add to the jazz repertory. Randy has toured Europe some twenty times and continues to appear across the country at jazz parties while pursuing his unique sound for the future.*

*Randy was interviewed at the Jerome Jazz Party in Aspen, Colorado on October 10, 1997, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.*

MR: We are filming in Aspen, Colorado today and I'm pleased to have Randy Sandke, trumpeter and arranger and composer for our guest for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

RS: Well thanks.

MR: Welcome.

RS: Pleasure to be here.

MR: I have to admit that I prejudged your playing, your sound. Because as I looked at some of the press and I'd see your name connected with Dick Hyman revival things and all that, I said I think I know what to expect from this gentleman. And then I heard this:
[audio interlude]

RS: Right. But that's still pretty mainstream stuff. That's nothing too far out.

MR: But it's an interesting, a great introduction for this tune. How did you conceive of this?

RS: Well that's actually the verse of the tune.

MR: That's the verse.

RS: That is the written verse, yeah. I think we might have added a few changes or something. But no that's really part of the tune.

MR: It sounds hipper than I thought it was going to be. Nice.

RS: Right. I think the one that really threw people for a loop was the record after this, which had Ray Anderson and Michael Brecker. And the first tune on it was "Lullaby of Broadway." And I know that some, I think it was Jazzbo Collins, you know he got the record, oh Randy Sandke, well this will be a nice kind of like, you know, easy listening jazz, and put it on, and it's supposed to be this Kafkaesque picture of, you know, New York at rush hour kind of thing. And so he was a little bit thrown for a loop. So that

MR: Would you bring in Michael Brecker and that crew and do that at the Aspen festival?

RS: Well I mean it's not, you know I don't really hire the people here. But that is one of the, I don't know, that's an aspect of jazz today and it's kind of, sometimes it's problematical for me because people tend to get labeled and pigeon-holed and I understand that. I think it's, you know it's probably a better career move to be identified with one thing. You're more salable. People know what to expect. But me personally, I have a hard time with that just because of I think the various kind of accidents that sort of formed my personal career, which I mean I can go into now if you want.

MR: Yeah, we'll get to that.

RS: Or whatever, yeah.

MR: But continuing that thought, do you ever feel that you are not included in things that you could be because you're considered mainstream?

RS: Definitely. Definitely yeah, right.

MR: So it's a double edged sword to have a label I supposed. Because you will be invited to these jazz parties, but you might not be included in —

RS: No I think that definitely happens, yeah.

MR: And the record companies seem to focus on a few of the "young lions" business and put their strength behind them.

RS: Right, which is fine. I mean I don't begrudge them. I mean I think most of the ones that get the attention are extremely talented and they're terrific players. The only thing that bothers me a little bit is that it seems like some styles count today and others don't, and if you look at it from a creative viewpoint it's a little mysterious because to me it seems like if the young guy plays like Freddie Hubbard or Woody Shaw, that's taken seriously. Whereas if you listen to Buck Clayton and Louis Armstrong that's not. To me, they're both equal repertoire at this point. And one of the things that troubles me, I mean it used to be a basic tenet of jazz that to be a major player you really had to say something different that was really, you know, almost more than just having a personal style. The great players would influence all musicians on all instruments because they were really taking it in a new direction. And now it seems like the marketing has kind of taken over and so they want to sell something. In order to sell something you have to sell something that people are kind of already familiar with. So much to do is made about guys who are very talented, but a kind of, you know, treading on ground that's been pretty well cultivated before, and it's done quite well and everything and that's fine, but I guess, and I understand all the dynamics of it from the record companies, the magazines, etcetera. I guess if I have a criticism maybe it's to the critics, who should be saying well this is fine but trying to encourage some of the more creative things going on. And that I find a little

MR: Jazz has moved awful fast in its history it seems like.

RS: Yeah, sure.

MR: And I'm constantly wondering where can it go from here? I mean it's been through the electronic end of it.

RS: Well I mean there's a lot in musical terms that could be developed that hasn't been in terms of even harmony in terms of extended forms, compositionally, I mean there's a whole lot of things that could be done. And it is being done and it will be done and all that, but I think that this at particular moment that's not what's really being focused on. You know it's more kind of the attitude seems to be we're going to take a breather from all of this because all the crazy — because the innovation was getting too crazy and too removed from the audience. So now it's time to just kind of retrench and establish an audience or institutionalize jazz, concentrate on its classic history and all that. And that's fine, you know, that's great. But you have to be careful that it doesn't go the way of classical music and just become a museum piece. It's got to be living, it's got to be new, it's got to be daring, it's got to be innovative too.

MR: To help to grab a young audience.

RS: Well yeah, yeah. And that's happening. I mean there are players like Dave Douglas, you know a very fine trumpet player who is really starting, just beginning to get the attention he deserves, and he's kind of associated with that Knitting Factory crowd, which has been kind of on the fringe, but some of that stuff is getting very sophisticated, some of the musicians who do it are terrific and they're really doing some interesting things. I mean that's just to name one example, I mean there are other people around too.

MR: Well you started out with some influence from your older brother?

RS: Yes, Gordon, that's right.

MR: And kind of, you are just about my age, and I remember listening to certain, a lot of pop music and then being greatly affected by groups like Blood, Sweat & Tears and stuff. Was that something — did you share that?

RS: Well yeah, I mean not them specifically. Basically how I got into listening to jazz was I guess through my older brother. I mean our parents had some 78s that belonged to I guess their parents. And it was a very mixed bag. But in it were some kind of interesting things. Nothing great, but I mean like there was something by "The Georgians" like this little combo from the 20s, and Bob Crosby's Bobcats with Bob Haggart, which was really nice, great arrangement that he did, you know, some jazz things. And that just caught our ear, and my brother started playing drums and so we had a drumset in the house and so I started playing and I always was trying to keep up with my older brother, then he brought a trumpet home and so I started playing the trumpet. And he started buying these jazz

Beiderbecke Story on Columbia, which George Avakian did. So when I was 10, 11, 12, I was really absorbed in that. And pretty soon thereafter we were listening to Clifford Brown and Dizzy Gillespie. And one thing, this was in the late 50s — well early 60s I guess. One advantage that we had was that a lot of these people were still around then. So I could hear them. I only heard Louis once, but it was just a completely mind-altering experience. And Duke Ellington I was fortunate to hear when he still had his band with Johnny Hodges and Harry Carney. We were in Chicago and there was this beautiful theater on the campus there at the University of Chicago, it's called Mandel Hall. It's a small theatre and beautiful acoustics. And we just came in early and we were sitting in the front row and they were just all there, you know, Cootie Williams, all these people. And it was just awe-inspiring. So those experiences really changed my life. Coltrane I heard. A lot of people I only unfortunately heard once, but at least I heard them once. You know I would hear Miles with his various quintets and all that.

MR: So your parents must have been fairly supportive.

RS: Yeah. They were. I mean they were university people, they were pretty broad-minded. They didn't seem to have a problem with me wanting to be a musician, which was very fortunate, because that can be a real conflict for some people if their parents say you know—

MR: Can't you just keep it as a sideline maybe?

RS: Right, yeah.

MR: And what was your first actual ensemble experience where you started to make a few dollars?

RS: Well I was working in high school with some bands, mostly rock bands. There was one band that I played in which was just two electric guitars and bass guitar and drums and trumpet. And I remember because they used to play everything in the key of E and A. So I used to, I actually borrowed this cornet that I could like play, I think if I pushed the slides all the way in I could kind of play in — rather than have to play in F sharp and B, I could play in F and B flat or something like that. I don't know. But it worked out some crazy way. And I had to play, you know it was good experience just to play. I was always playing all kind of different music from the start. The downside of it was that I started developing this problem which really caught up with me later which was that playing with these amplified instruments — I mean back then the amplification thing was pretty new. And people didn't do the sound systems people used, and the micing wasn't that sophisticated. And usually if you were a horn playing with amplified instruments you were kind of at a disadvantage.

MR: I guess.

RS: That coupled with the fact that I was pretty much self-taught. I had some lessons but as far as just basic technique, I had a few bad habits that really caught up with me with a vengeance. To make a long story short, I ended up developing this problem in my throat which was kind of like a hernia. There's a tear in the muscle in my throat which got worse and worse and worse kind of through my first couple of years of college to the point that I just decided screw this.

MR: No more trumpet.

RS: Yes. So I ended up quitting for ten years.

MR: No kidding?

RS: Yeah. I didn't touch the horn.

MR: Did it heal itself?

RS: Well when I was 19 I had an operation on it, which at the time, because I really didn't know what was causing the problem, and I was kind of perpetuating the same bad habits, that after it healed and everything and I started playing, it started doing the same thing. So I didn't think it was a success. But I think it had pretty much, it had taken care of the problems. So ten years later when I started playing again, which was almost totally by accident, I immediately decided well if I'm going to do this I want to start with a teacher, an excellent classical player, started studying with this man Vince Penzarella who plays in the Philharmonic and is great. He taught Jon Faddis and Wynton Marsalis and you know, I just can't say enough about the guy. He's great. And he also, he had been in a car accident and really messed up his face and so he had to start — he had been a professional and he had to start again. And so he'd been through a similar thing and he really had to analyze how you do it. So that was just perfect to have hooked up with him at the time I did and just start over with a clean slate. And he really made me understand just the basic dynamics of playing the trumpet, which are fairly simple but whether you get them intuitively or learn them, I mean it's like the laws of physics and biology. I mean you have to work in harmony with them. If you don't it's going to be trouble. So you learn those thing, you absorb that, and then you can go on.

MR: You were able to stay in music in those ten years though?

RS: Well sort of. I had a pretty checkered history in there. I was at Indiana University and then I went back to Chicago and ended up working in the library — the biomedical library sciences building there for a while. I saved enough money to buy a car, get out of town, ended up in Bennington, Vermont because I had some friends from high school that were there, and ended up accompanying for dance classes. But also I was working at this fast food restaurant. But I ended up being there for about three years and then ended up leaving. It kind of, it's not worth going through this huge story. If we had two hours

that name. He's a trumpet player and teacher, a kind of avante garde leaning guy. But we just had some problems and so I decided it was time to move on. And I came to New York and started playing guitar, continued playing piano accompanying for dance classes, was running an elevator, you know, doing all kinds of odd jobs. By the end of the 70s I was playing five nights a week in this funky little club on the upper west side which is long gone called Clifford's Lounge.

MR: Playing guitar?

RS: Playing guitar. And so I was starting to make a meager existence playing music. But the one thing that I realized was that — I kept on thinking well if I get the chops together I'll start enjoying it as much as trumpet. Well I started developing technique and I got so that I could play it okay. But I never liked it as much. And it was only at the time when I started to get kind of a little bit proficient that I realized that there are some things that always bothered me about the guitar after playing the trumpet, one of which is that the sound is coming out of another place. It's coming out of this amp over here. I could never get used to that. You know you're playing here — a trumpet is just like an extension of your head, it feels like part of your body. Guitar always felt, with the electronics and everything, and to control your sound by turning dials and all that, I just could never — and not to mention hauling the amp around I mean I hated that. So about that time an old friend of mine from Indiana University just wanted to come to New York and we had an extra room in the apartment that we had that I was sharing with some other musicians. And so he came in and he knew me from when I was a trumpet player. And he said to me, "if you don't want to play that's one thing, but if you think it's because of some physical thing, I really think that there's a way to get around it and you should at least try." His name is Michael Gribrock. And he's still a really good friend of mine. And he talked me into just — here was a trumpet player who had had a lot of problems and stayed in Indiana, stuck it out studying and kind of managed to get over some of these things. And so the horn was there and I started to play it. And I realized immediately that whether I could play it well or just do it as a hobby, immediately I just enjoyed it much more. And it's obvious that's what it's all about. So I thought all right, what the hell, I'll just see what happens. And then shortly after I started studying with Vince Penzarella, about six months later my brother moved to town and there was a job he couldn't make and so he said, "could you sub for me?" And so I ended up six months later I was working in New York, with no expectations of it being a career or anything. But it just kind of evolved.

MR: That first time after, picking up the trumpet after ten years, did your chops remember what it felt like?

RS: Well yeah kind of, although I was conscious that I wanted to play differently than I had before because if I was going to do this I didn't want to have the same problem. My fingers, when Mike was teaching me in the beginning said, "I'm used to teaching beginners who don't know the fingerings, and here, it's like —." So I tried to play. I wasn't trying to play high, loud, anything. But I would just play tunes, middle register things, and I really from the start felt that connection again.

MR: Was your experience with the guitar and the piano, did that help your trumpet improvising?

RS: Well I mean I guess it didn't hurt, although before I had had a pretty good grounding in harmony. And I think what it's helped is my writing a bit. For instance in guitar one of the things you concentrate on is how to voice chords with two notes, with three notes, with more notes than that. For instance if you're a horn player the difference between a C7 and a C9 is negligible because what you play on top of it is virtually the same. But when you play a rhythm instrument there are quite different sounds. Also, I think where it helped was just being part of the rhythm section too. Because that's really a different head. And that's why a lot of guys play drums, play bass, play piano or something like that. Because as a horn player you can't just sort of float on top of everything else. When you're a rhythm section player it's a different perception. A horn player tends to hear the whole thing as a unity. And when you're a rhythm section player you're always trying to, you're aware of your meshing your individual sound, what you're doing, with the others, to try to get this common groove going. In a way it's a little more work as a rhythm player I think.

MR: You have to find your spot in the quartet.

RS: Yeah. Like you're always working to make it gel. Whereas as a horn player working with a rhythm section you're kind of already feeling the totality of it.

MR: So after the trumpet became part of you again, you entered into the competitive scene in New York City?

RS: Right.

MR: When I look at the Local 802 book I see page after page of trumpets, page after page of saxophones.

RS: Well they're mostly part-time guys. Well see the thing was that I was able to find a niche. I mean this is kind of interesting because this is sort of where this thing developed in my career, which has been kind of a blessing and a curse. Because now my orientation, when I left college — I went to college with Michael Brecker and I mean the stuff he was listening to then, his listening habits were a little more advanced than mine, I would say when we were in school, when we were like 18 or 19. I'd say mine were a little broader

Shorter or Miles was doing. Just when these records came out he had them. He was like listening to them day and night. And so that was part of it. When I was in college I mean Freddie Hubbard was my idol. I loved Freddie Hubbard and I liked to play in that sort of way. Well when I'm in New York and now it's like early 80s, I just decided that I wanted to play and I wanted to take any jobs I could and get as close to jazz work as possible. Well at that time I just found this niche working in traditional jazz, which I didn't know existed. I didn't know that I was going to become a part of it. But the thing is because I had started out listening to that music and it was so much a part of my consciousness — you know, Louis, Bix, those tunes. I remember sitting down and making a tune list, because Ed Polcer was working at Eddie Condon's. This was the last Eddie Condon's on 54th Street. And he was always looking for subs and there just weren't that many guys, especially younger guys, who knew the stuff. And so I just wrote down a list of tunes, of the old tunes. And I was — it just kind of astounded me how many of them I just knew already. So that was an advantage right there. So then I'm working at Condon's and then I'm kind of in this freelance pool and working with Vince Giordano's Night Hawks and then Bob Wilber and then Benny Goodman and all of that. And at that time I mean maybe because there was a sort of stigma, there always has been except maybe until very recently, about playing — I mean there still is to an extent — playing older styles. There were just very few people doing it. Also the original, the guys of that generation who were doing it, they were getting in their 60s, 70s, 80s. If they weren't dead they were like out of commission. And I would get work that way. For instance I can remember a tour that Billy Butterfield was supposed to do and he had some health problems and so I had to step in and do it. Things like that. And that sort of got me into the jazz party circuit and here I am now. And now, like I should make it clear, I've always had this emotional connection to this music, to that style, or those styles. I mean it's a pretty broad spectrum in itself. But there's always been this other part of me too that has wanted to do really creative things and not imitate Freddie Hubbard or Woody Shaw but like do stuff that nobody else is doing.

MR: Which shows up on your recent records.

RS: To an extent, although I think the more adventuresome stuff that I've done has not been recorded. Some of it I'm starting to. Again, to back up, it's 1985 when I was working with Benny Goodman and almost all my work was in that swing-Dixieland kind of stuff. I financed my own first record, just saved up I think it was $5,000, and hired, got Mike Brecker and Jim McNealy and John Goldsby, Kenny Washington and did all originals in a modern context. That was my first record. And it got — I still — in some ways I still like that the best. I mean I think I'm a better trumpet player now but I feel good about

wherever it was, whenever it was reviewed. But it led to absolutely nothing in the way of work. No jobs, no nothing. Couldn't get into clubs, nobody was hiring me as a sideman, nothing, nothing. So I continued working, getting more and more established in this vein, and also traveling to Europe, getting more established over there everywhere as this mainstream trumpet player. Then by the early 90s — so I'm working with like the younger guys I'm working are some of the guys who are here — Ken Peplowski, Howard Alden, Scott Hamilton, guys who are on Concord. And this was when of course Carl Jefferson was still alive, who is the founder. And largely through Ken I ended up getting on Concord and I still record for them. Now Carl Jefferson, his niche that he found for that record company was to record all this mainstream music which the other labels had totally neglected in this country, and especially the younger guys like Scott Hamilton, Warren Vache and people like that that were out there making a living, getting like the people who listened to them. I mean they really have their fan base — whatever you want to call that constituency. And yet a lot of times they're really kind of ignored in the larger jazz press or something, and by the record companies. So Carl found that well there's this audience, there's this gulf between what this group of the audience wants to hear and what's being presented and so he was able to do that, and became quite successful. So as I say largely through Ken I was introduced to Carl and I ended up getting signed by Concord. But it was still kind of in the guise of a mainstream artist. And so the records, I've just done my fifth. They kind of started out, like my first record with them I just decided well I'm going to make a nice, happy little mainstream jazz record. And one of the problems was that when I was going to the jobs like such as this or the jazz parties, I couldn't really take that record that I'd done because it alienated people. It still has that effect. I mean I won't mention any names but there is still a guy who will not hire me because his first experience of listening to me was hearing that record and he can't reconcile the fact well that — I mean this guy — like I just want to play mainstream or whatever, and I'm afraid he's going to start playing a Woody Shaw lick or something and ruin the whole —. So I saw that problem and I needed something to sell and to promote for this direction my career was going. So I made this record and just tried to make it as well as I could at the time. And then with each successive one I've tried to be a little bit more adventurous, to the third one, which Carl Jefferson was there. And I had him okay Ray Anderson, Mike Brecker, Smitty Smith. And he said fine. And just before we did it he came to New York and we were having dinner the night before we did it and he was saying to me, "you know you can't be all things to all people. You have to decide what you want to do." Which was a little deflating to hear just before I'm about to do this record which is really going to be going in another direction, and I'm thinking well he's

tune I think we did was that "Lullaby of Broadway." And surprising enough he liked it, and he heard Ray Anderson and he said, "Wow, this guy's great." Which was really nice that I felt like he sort of trusted me and if he heard it and he heard that there was some integrity to it, that he would go along with it. So that was encouraging. Then a short year after that he died. And so now the company is kind of going through a little bit of financial insanity but supposedly everything is going to continue. The last record that I did for them was totally different. Because I've been — I kind of found a little more freedom in the writing area, that I'm not so pigeon-holed and I can do more daring things in writing. So the last record that I did was with a symphony orchestra. It's not out yet, it'll be out in a couple of months. And I did things on that from contemporary classical music to modern. And even what I got to put on this record is — after my first record, about a year or two later I did a second record, which was kind of going further into more personal areas, different kinds of stuff. And I could not get any record company interested in it. There was just no interest at all. And I invested a lot of money in the project. Finally ten years later some of that is going to be released which is symphony stuff. And I have to admit that's the stuff that's closest to my heart because it's the stuff that is more just me.

MR: Is that where you did the arrangements on the Bach?

RS: Well there's one piece that's kind of from that. But the first symphony concert that Ken Peplowski and I did we did, I wrote three things: an arrangement of Ellington-Strayhorn tunes which will be on this record; and then this version of the Brandenburg, I mean the Goldberg variations, where the orchestra would play a variation and then the jazz quintet would do a variation on the same material; and also this other piece which is on the record which is just kind of contemporary classical music. I like to write, I've kind of developed a way of writing and improvising which I really want to go into more. I've done some but it hasn't been recorded too much, which involves — it's like a way of relating harmonically, like relating melodically to a harmony but not a tonal harmony. So you're playing on changes but it's not based on scales and it's not based on chords you can write with conventional chord symbols. And there's just a lot there that hasn't been tapped.

MR: It reminds me of Ornette Coleman's—

RS: The Harmolodic.

MR: The Harmolodic but I'm not sure I understand it.

RS: Well see that's the thing. See that's something that again bothers me, and to me shows a deficiency of the jazz criticism and the fact that I mean like some of the jazz critics I have good relationships with, some I would even, one or two I would even consider kind of

background, which that doesn't invalidate all their opinions, but I think sometimes it puts them at a disadvantage. And the thing is, take for instance Ornette Coleman. And I have great respect for him, especially the stuff he did with Don Cherry, a lot of that stuff I think is great. And he really opened up things, and an incredibly important figure. But for instance like "Harmolodic" is this term that every musician knows but nobody knows what it is. And I'll say I'm not sure that Ornette Coleman, if it is a specific thing. I mean he's got an approach, I don't mean to deny that, but to say like you can break it down the way you can like a Baroque contrapuntal technique or something, I don't think it's that specific. Well the stuff that I've worked on it is very specific. It does really relate music to harmony. I'm not saying that it's the greatest thing since sliced bread, but I'm saying that it does deserve a little bit of attention and I'll tell you, and I've been doing it live in New York, I've been doing it for ten years. It's been like pulling teeth.

MR: An uphill battle.

RS: Yeah. Which is not to say — the way it works, that part of my career, it's like this part of my career, I have a good time, I love these guys, I love playing the music and I make money and every year, I mean the jobs are fine. I mean here we are in this nice hotel. But for doing the other kind of stuff, it means using the money I make for that too, to like finance a concert, finance a record, finance this or that. And it gets increasingly hard for me to do, especially if I do that I mean just to give you one example, a couple of years ago I did a concert. I tried to get an NEA grant. I'd gotten a couple before but this one, they're getting harder and harder to get. I didn't get it, no funding at all. So I spent $9,000 of my own on a concert, and Mike Brecker was there, Chris Potter — I put together a great band, rehearsed all this new music. One of the things that I did, which I was interested in doing — the idea of the concert was kind of to use longer forms, kind of like classical forms, in a jazz context. So one of the things I wrote was this thing called "Symphony for Six," which was in a symphony form, but for sextet. And it was all using this new harmonic stuff that I'm working on. And Chip Deffaa from *The Post* was there and he loved it. He wrote a really nice review. Peter Watrous was there from *The Times* and he didn't, he just didn't get it. And so he wrote, you know, just a very, very dismissive article. And so that's not enough to stop me and say well hell I'm not going to do this. Of course I'm going to do it but it makes me think, is it worth it to spend $9,000 and all I end up with is a bad review in the *Times*? So it just makes me think that as far as — one of the things that I've kind of decided is that the label jazz is a very tricky thing these days. And I've noticed this with people like John Zorn, who's been very successful, and I mean again like I don't mean to — I like the group he's got, Masada, with Dave Douglas. I love — I've heard some of his orchestral stuff. He's a very talented guy. He's

tried, or he tried to get himself over as this "downtown scene" musician, avoiding the label jazz, avoiding the comparisons with Coltrane and the young lions and the black and white thing and whatever — he just sidesteps that and he finds his audience and he gets his — he establishes his way. And I'm kind of finding the same thing. If I try to promote this as jazz you run up into a million hurdles from all kinds of directions. If I on the other hand go into a contemporary classical music direction I find that it's like all these barriers break away.

MR: No kidding?

RS: Yeah.

MR: That there's more room for something new in that particular field?

RS: Well I mean there's a lot of reasons for it. For one thing I think the critics have at least gone to music school and know something about music. For another thing, well it's already institutionalized. There is funding, there is money, the whole structure of it. I mean just briefly one example, I mean I've had this kind of running battle with BMI, who I'm a member of, because they don't pay for live performances of jazz, but they pay for live performances of classical music. So in other words, for instance, like two nights ago I wrote this huge thing for the Carnegie Hall Jazz Band. I mean it was an arrangement so I wouldn't have technically gotten paid. But I have had jazz compositions performed at Lincoln Center and Carnegie Hall. I don't make a dime. I can have a score that's like an inch thick. But I go out to Tulsa, Oklahoma with a regional symphony orchestra and play a classical piece, and I get a nice check in the mail. So I mean that's just an example of the way society, here in the form of BMI, is encouraging — because to get paid for your work, that's encouragement — is encouraging classical music. Whereas if it's jazz, if it's even called jazz, even if it's almost the same piece, you're treated totally differently. Also I just find a lot of — I think in classical music there's more openness to do new things, and especially, the irony of the whole thing is that basically I'm still, even when I'm doing things that are what I consider on my idea, the cutting edge, I'm still basically conservative. So that for classical musical, like the stuff that I write, even though it's harmonically maybe to the point of atonal, it's still very melodic, it still has form you can follow. It's not crazy, formless. I try very hard to make it —

MR: It's not free jazz.

RS: Yeah, no. And the jazz that I play is not free, like that too. I mean it's always got a structure, it always has like a form I want people to follow and understand, it's got melodies. Now somebody told me, I don't know if this is true, It almost pissed me off too much if I found it were true, but that at *The New York Times* that it's kind of policy, and I don't know who said it, but they've decided that the whole concept of melody is passé,

isn't true and it might not be. But it's ludicrous. I mean to me, a melody, that's the basic thing that people comprehend from music, and the great jazz players are the ones that were able to make melodies on the spot. So at any rate, that's what I'm trying to do in classical music. And I think there's a kind of a thirst for things that are contemporary but still accessible. And I think I can do that. With jazz on the other hand I feel that something that seems innovative right now is just a little threatening. People really don't want it, unless it comes from certain people — like if somehow Wynton Marsalis starts imitating Duke Ellington and does something new—

MR: It'll be okay.

RS: It'll be okay. But I get the feeling with me it's not going to be.

MR: So it's more the name than what they're producing.

RS: Yeah. It's just a lot of factors and almost none of them have to do with music. And again I don't mean to say, like Wynton Marsalis is a great musician and all the respect in the world, but I'm just saying that as far as the focus on jazz these days, I think it's gotten pretty far away from music a lot of the time.

MR: Well you probably wouldn't get a very sympathetic ear at this particular festival if you were to try to do some of that.

RS: Yeah. And I understand that and it's fine.

MR: In fact I remember last night just hearing comments around me. These people, they certainly know what they like.

RS: Well yeah, sure.

MR: And if you go a little above their heads, they'll just say things like, "oooh, that went right through my head" or something. I hear these little bits and pieces.

RS: Yeah. And I mean that brings up another kind of interesting facet is this whole idea, which I've really had to face, of playing older styles which are really basically formed. Like these styles are set, but to try to play it, I mean like here is, okay I have this career, this is what I do. Is it possible to do it in a creative way and in a personal way? And I have come to the belief that yes it is. I don't mean to hold myself as a great example, but people like Kenny Davern, Warren Vache, Scott Hamilton, to me they're very personal voices. They don't sound like a copy of anybody else. You can't say Kenny Davern is a clone of Pee Wee Russell or Benny Goodman. He sounds like Kenny Davern. And yet he's playing now in the style that was kind of set decades before. He's still creative and he's still — I mean there's a way of doing it. And I think that's valid too. And I think some critics seem to be aware of that and others aren't. But I mean that's a difficult thing to pull off.

MR: Well you've certainly played with a long list of the really established veterans, and they seem to embrace your approach. The World's Greatest Jazz Band and Benny Carter. Is there a group of people that you really, really look forward to playing with?

RS: Well I feel that like one of the problems that I have is that when I do my own records or these projects which are more modern, that even conceptually I might have an idea of what I want to do but there's a difference between that and playing every night in a certain context. This is the context I usually find myself in. And again, I love these guys, I love playing the music. But I would also love to play, say, Smitty Smith is doing "The Tonight Show" now but if he weren't, work with him. I feel like I would grow so much as a player if I could just play with him on a regular basis, or to get a chance to work with — I mean there's a lot of people — Chick Corea, Herbie Hancock, I mean I would love to play with those people. I don't know if I ever will, and if I ever did I mean I would like to work with them for a period of time and really absorb. Elvin Jones I mean I'd love to play with that guy. And I feel like it would help me so much. But even if I was going to play with guys or influences that are coming out of that style, just to get a chance to do it on a nightly basis, is very, very difficult.

MR: I think that's a very important thing you mentioned, is that it's not going to happen in one night. I mean if you played with Chick Corea for one night, it would be a thrill but to play with him for a time would cause you to expand your own vocabulary perhaps.

RS: Right, yeah. So I mean I guess in a way it's good to always have some things that you want to do that maybe you'll do, maybe you never will. But there's a lot of things that I would like to do that I haven't done. Sure.

MR: You had said some pretty kind words about George Avakian? That he gave you some good career boosts along the way. Or is it mostly just listening to his productions?

RS: Well of course I grew up listening to a lot of the things that he did for Columbia, which is not only the reissues but the Miles Davis and Gil Evans. It was his idea to bring those two together. In fact he says he went to Miles and Miles had done all these quintet records and he said, "now that you're with Columbia, we want to present you in a different way and like put you in a new direction, and we can get this budget together." And he said, "why don't you have somebody write something sort of big band or orchestrally, like Gunther Schuller or Gil Evans?" And of course Miles knew Gil and ended up picking Gil Evans. But George Avakian was very much a part of that. You know a lot of good — Sonny Rollins, Duke Ellington stuff, all kinds of things. But he was out of the business for a long — I mean I didn't know if he was still alive or dead. And then just maybe six, seven years ago or something I was playing in a club and somebody brought him in. And I couldn't believe how young he looked and I mean he was like in really good health and

that he did. And he had really been kind of out of it so long and he didn't have really good feelings about the record business, the way it had been run and the way it was being run. But since that time I mean I have to say he's gotten back into it. He's doing a lot of work for CBS-SONY with reissue projects. And then just recently this last June for the JVC festival we co-produced a concert which was this — he managed to find these Louis Armstrong compositions that Louis had never recorded, many of them written in his own hand, in the Library of Congress. So there was about eight or nine things that nobody knew was there, and hadn't been heard. So we put on a concert where we played them, Nicholas Payton and myself. And then we did some Bix Beiderbecke things in the first half, and it got a lot of publicity and hopefully we're going to make a record and do a tour next year.

MR: Did I read that you used some of his own instruments on that?

RS: Oh yeah. That was kind of an interesting thing. And well George was kind of responsible for getting, there's this couple, Bob Christensen and his wife, that live in California. And they have Bix Beiderbecke's cornet. It was engraved with his name on it and everything like that. A Bach, this silver Bach cornet. And they just agreed to come to the concert at their own expense and lend us the cornet, and I had never met these people. And it was unbelievable. And then of course there's the Louis Armstrong Archive at Queens College, and a guy named Michael Cogswell is kind of a friend, is the curator there. And part of that, of what they have, is six or seven horns that belonged to Louis. So I went out there. He let me play them, one other time, and he graciously lent us one for the concert, so I went over there and I picked one that I liked. And I'd never played the Bix horn until a half hour before the concert.

MR: No kidding.

RS: Yeah. And I kind of assumed that it was going to be in real bad shape and probably had never been cleaned out, that it was leaky, you know. But the thing just played great. It was like the best cornet that I'd ever played. So we were thinking we would just kind of display them in the front. But we didn't know that we would actually play the horns. We ended up, and then the second half, Nicholas tried the Selmer trumpet of Louis' and the first thing he says was, "where can I get one of these?" So he ended up playing that for the second half. It was very moving.

MR: Did they make him wear white gloves when he played? I got to visit out there and every time he would take something off the shelf—

RS: At the archive there?

MR: Yeah. Very, very — treated with great respect.

RS: No, he's great. He's really doing a fantastic job with that stuff. He didn't make me wear

audience, I said I almost hesitate to do this because there might still be a little DNA in there and we could clone these guys. I don't want to do anything that might —

MR: Put my own in there.

RS: Right. Contaminate that.

MR: Get saliva samples from the horn. That's wild.

RS: Right. But that was a thrill, it was a real thrill.

MR: Well we were talking a little earlier about the concept of improvising.

RS: Right.

MR: And you had mentioned you have done some interviews with people about that, what they think of how they do it. And can you articulate what you're thinking if you're playing "Ain't Misbehavin'" for instance, and you're improvising over the changes, is there something — a thought process — that you can talk about?

RS: Well it's funny because I said I've done these interviews. I've never been interviewed myself on this subject. So I don't, I'm just speaking off the top of my head. But from my own experience it's the less thinking the better. The more you feel like you're part of the whole group, and that the music is just kind of there, you're just sort of pulling it out of the air, the better you are. And I have that feeling when I write too by the way, which is not that I am really creating it, but it's like the thing is there. It's like you talk about Michelangelo's "David" I mean it's like the stone is there but he sees the thing. It's already in there, he just chips away to get at it. And that's the way it always feels when I'm writing. It's kind of like prospecting. It's like the gold is there. It's like all these great compositions that have never been written, they're all there, you just have to find them. And it's not like, it doesn't feel like I'm the one that's doing it, it's just somehow your taste or what you — something unconscious is deciding what's gold and what's not in there. But that's the thing, you have to kind of have — I guess — some sort of discrimination, some kind of feeling for well this does something to me and this doesn't. I think you have to have that kind of feeling, to decide. Because what one person considers gold, another person might not. And that's kind of the beauty of it because that's why everybody plays differently. But you have to have — I guess the important thing is to have that feeling that for some reason this really turns me on, you know these notes, but these notes just don't – leave me cold, or this rhythm or something like that. And it's that kind of when it's working it's kind of feeling like you're not really doing it yourself. It's not a conscious thing, it's just sort of there, which is a pretty vague answer I guess.

MR: But I've heard it before, actually. Some people have used the word "Zen," you know it's a Zen experience. But I think the challenge with that is to try to relate that to younger

are just playing scales and they've got all this knowledge of chords and modes and blah, blah, blah but they're not creating melodies. And how do you tell them how to do that? Maybe it's not possible. Maybe that's what makes the jazz cream rise to the top.

RS: Yeah. I mean I don't know that that's so much a generational thing because I think it's always been like that. There've been a few players that can just make it sing and take wings and whatever, and a lot of people for whatever reason, it's just less than that. And there are some players these days that I think are quite lyrical, and even younger players, and then guys who are not. One thing, going back to another thing about playing, one thing that sort of interests me, I mean I guess is that Louis Armstrong for instance, he always, he could play with the worst band in the world and at times — not the worst band but guys that were just on a totally different — I mean nobody was on his level, but I mean like way under. And he would say that he didn't even hear the band. Like he would just play, he just had such a strong feeling inside him that he would just charge ahead and it would just fall into place. And he could do that. And of course, that's him. I cannot do that. I mean I can do that to a certain extent, but I always feel very much like I'm playing WITH the guys and that my playing is affected, for better or worse, by what's going on around me. And sometimes I feel like it's very difficult for me to like really get it happening if it doesn't seem like it is around me. You know I'll try, but I mean I guess that's the nature of the thing. Sometimes you feel like it's work, other times it's just happening by itself. And it doesn't necessarily, there are so many variables. It's not just even the caliber of the musicians. The night after last we were doing this thing at Carnegie Hall and I played a few small group things. The rhythm section was terrific. Some of the tunes felt really good. The last tune we did, it just felt like — I mean I don't know if the audience perceived this. But it just felt like for whatever reason it just was not coming together, it was an effort all the way through. And it sounded okay, I mean nobody did any obvious goofs. But to me it just didn't really have the feeling. It wasn't comfortable. And of course like when you don't feel comfortable, there's always a tendency to blame yourself. I think when you've got experience you tend to notice a little bit more that it's other things too. But you just get into so many variables — the weather, how people are feeling, the acoustics.

MR: Yeah. You only have so much control over the situation.

RS: Right. And that's part of it. I mean like if you're just doing it a lot you just have to do it regardless of what it feels like. And also know that it changes. I mean you can start off feeling like you're kind of beating a dead horse or walking a mountain uphill. But then it can catch on and then you forget it.

MR: These situations at the jazz festivals where you have three or four horns on stage and you pick a standard, is it that much different from the New Orleans jazz, as far as how the ensemble works? Does it pretty much date back to that?

RS: Well it depends. If you're playing with a clarinet and a trombone and you're playing with guys that kind of come out of that tradition, I mean there's certain roles that people tend to play. Like if I'm playing with Kenny Davern say and Dan Barrett, then like we'll do that kind of playing where I stick fairly close to the lead, fairly close to the melody, improvising more on the melody. Kenny is playing above me, usually more notes, more obbligato, and Dan will be playing below, kind of like an embellished, embroidered, kind of a bass part. But with those guys, because they're so great at it, they can kind of find their instant harmony parts, where they're kind of, where the clarinet kind of plays the next harmony below the trumpet but an octave above. You know they just know what to do. And even though it's still free and there's a million different ways they could do it, they're still very attuned to that kind of playing. Then some of the other guys, like say for instance like guys like Conte Candoli — I don't know if there are too many other guys around here like that, or maybe Joe Temperly. They come out of a different sort of school which is in a kind of the swing-bebop thing where people when they play head it tends to be unison. Just play the melody. Like Charlie Parker and Dizzy would do it or something like that. And those are two completely different ways. And sometimes you get caught in between, where it's like a little bit up for grabs, and it can feel slightly uncomfortable at times. My preference is that even when I'm playing — for instance I did a gig not too long ago with Jon Gordon, who is a great saxophone player. He's the guy who just won the Thelonious Monk competition on saxophone. And we were playing all these heads and it's trumpet and alto, and that traditional thing is to play unison. Well we didn't have time to rehearse. It's always a little dangerous because our conception, we might have different ideas of how a rhythm goes or the melody, and to me nothing sounds worse than you're playing this unison and then suddenly it goes out of sync.

MR: Not quite unison, yeah.

RS: So I just told him, I'll play the melody and you improvise around it or play a harmony or a background part or something. I prefer that, unless you can really rehearse specifically what you want to do. Or it's a head that everybody knows. Like last night they did "Donna Lee" and everybody up there knew it so they could play that in unison. But even a lot of tunes that people, everybody knows, they might phrase it differently. Right. So it's just kind of like a gray area sometimes. But that's one of the things that's interesting about these jazz parties. They were kind of started by this guy Dick Gibson in Denver. And when he started doing it he was bringing together guys from the Dixieland tradition

meet on too much common musical ground. They were still thought of as pretty separate. And I think one of the contributions — if you want to call it that — of the jazz party has been kind of forcing these two styles together into a way that they can kind of coexist so that now you can have somebody like Phil Woods and Doc Cheatham is gone unfortunately, but the two of them could meet together and find some common ground and make it work. And in a way that's a kind of new development that doesn't really get much attention. But that is a development in jazz that it happened. It wasn't there 30, 40 years ago.

MR: Well to wrap up here, have you got any words of advice for up and coming jazz artists?

RS: Well I think the most creative part of the whole thing is getting your career going. And it's going to be different for everyone. And the people that do it are the ones that are — it's like they don't have any choice, this is what they have to do and they do it and they find a way and they meet the other guys that feel the same way and then somehow they start forming groups and you go through that period in your 20s where you're willing to sleep on floors and crash at people's places and do whatever it takes, and trust that hopefully you'll come out on the other side. I mean I think on the positive side it is — maybe some opportunities are opening up. It's kind of a double edged sword, this bit about the little bit more media. Jazz is kind of getting into the mainstream of American culture more then it has been, and with it comes all the other parts of mainstream culture, like just the kind of media focus on personalities, focus on looks, focus on this and that. But at the same time it's creating some kind of economic base, some money is coming in, it means opportunities, it means more people are talking about it and curious. And then there'll be more things going on in the margins that might be interesting. So it's tough, but it can be done, to turn it into a career, to do it. And I see young guys breaking in every year. I feel sorry for people moving to New York and having to deal with the expense and you've got to be prepared for having this double life of doing something else to make money or having some money saved up, until you get things rolling. And that can take some years. But people still do it. They still do it.

MR: Is there any kind of racial thing happening in jazz right now that could be better?

RS: Yeah. I think it definitely could be better. It's not across the board, I think it's just certain pockets of it. And I think in general it's — the musicians have always been open minded They can hear, they can tell what's going on. I mean I've had like for instance Bobby Watson, he once said to me, he said, "like I see so many white musicians being left behind, it's not right," and all that kind of stuff. And I mean they know what's going on. And I don't think — like white musicians I think feel very divided about it because they're aware of the fact, of course forget like all that social discrimination that blacks

limited for black players. I mean there's a lot of great black players from the 20s who like in the 30s were out of the music business and doing other things. So they had it rough. But the part that bothers me is just people who should be a little bit objective. I'm just bothered any time the focus is not on the music. Music should be judged on its own terms, not on racial terms. And I think one of the things I see happening is that jazz and the way it's being marketed, by promoters, producers, club owners and all that, it's kind of turning into — like the New York club scene to me seems like it's sort of turning to a folklore show. You know what I mean? I mean it's like you go down to Mexico and you go into the place, and so for the tourist, and they have all the people wear their fancy clothes and bring out the guitars and do all this stuff. Well they'd probably not be caught dead in that if they weren't getting paid to do that. And I mean I'm kind of stretching the point maybe a little. But I get the feeling that a lot of clubs in New York they feel like well a lot of money is coming from Japanese/ Europeans. They're trying to recreate a scene of what they want New York to be. And that's like having some young black guys play bebop, so that people can fantasize — oh man this is where Miles was and Trane — and that's great, and that's fine. But again that's not a musical consideration. And there are young black guys who are fantastic. But there are also young white guys too. And I mean it's like the older guys, I mean we're another situation. But I mean just to take an example, and I would say now Joshua Redman, I think he's one of the most talented of the younger musicians around today. I mean he knocks me out. He's a great, great player. But so is Chris Potter. Chris Potter knocks me out too. Now Chris is working, he's doing very well, he's getting records out, but there's no comparison between the kind of attention that Joshua gets, and also the freedom that Joshua gets to take his own group around. Because ultimately, see like it does ultimately have an effect on the music. Because here is one guy who is given the chance to develop his own thing. Now Chris can do that, but he's got less of a chance. And it's more like what I was talking about where maybe he'll get a group together for a record date a week before and do it. But that's different than having your own group to play at festival after festival for years. He's going to be at a disadvantage. And I don't want to say that it's going to make his music less strong, but it makes it harder for him. And it's just a reality of the situation now. And as I say that's one of the reasons that I want to kind of focus my creative, original stuff more in the direction of classical music, contemporary classical music, because just frankly, I'm really tired of dealing with the whole thing. I just am a musician. Either you like my music or not. But just take it on those terms. And I just feel like jazz, it's just like so many things have gotten in the way of that, for people like me. And as I say, I think the musicians themselves are pretty cool about it, although I am

there, as much as they deny it. And I've sat down and I've talked to Stanley Crouch, I know Stanley Crouch, I know Wynton Marsalis a little bit, I mean we've talked a couple of times. I think I've talked more in depth with Stanley Crouch. And like he says that it's not a racial thing, like we just want to develop the jazz canon and just focus, and we can't focus on Bix Beiderbecke until we've focused on all these other people and that's great. But you happened to mention, well what about Benny Goodman or what about Gil Evans and all, what about Bill Evans? Not that they should have whole concerts or whatever, but just to get his opinion. And he always like had some dismissive way of — like he'd say it's just by coincidence, he'll say it's not racial. But just coincidentally if you bring up the name of any white — "we will never do Benny Goodman." I mean I don't know — we've got to finish up here, I don't know when your next person is.

MR: We're okay.

RS: Yeah okay. But I mean it's like an irony. See like you got me going now. But an irony. Now take Benny Goodman, who was really until recently known for this guy who broke the color barrier. He was the guy that hired Lionel Hampton and Teddy Wilson and he was, like with Benny Goodman died, that week I was doing a concert opposite Lionel Hampton and Lionel Hampton said, he got to the microphone and he said, "Benny Goodman was the Abraham Lincoln of jazz. If it wasn't for him I wouldn't be here doing as well as I am." Now Benny Goodman was a strange personality and there's a lot of people that didn't like him and he was weird, there's no question about that, I can tell you first-hand, although that isn't the whole story. But for some reason I just see this thing happening, kind of like — I don't know if it's the Jewish thing, but it's similar to like there was so much of a Jewish sympathy for the Civil Rights movement and so many, like Schwerner and Chaney, whatever, you know shot down there. And then there's all this backlash against Jews. And I sort of find that, I mean I don't know if it's a Jewish thing or what it is, but for some reason, Benny Goodman, it's been turned around from that he was helping black people, to he was exploiting them. He was buying these Fletcher Henderson arrangements for $25 and not giving him credit or whatever, and Fletcher's band went out of business and Benny's making all these hits, and it's like instead of helping these black people it's like he's using them. And it's like all these motives get really, just like there's this lack of trust and lack of I think wanting to understand the situation. And I think there's a general willingness for maybe younger black musicians to believe that it was worse for the older musicians than it was. Because although I think that Duke Ellington, when those guys traveled down south it was horrible. Louis Armstrong. I mean that's on record. Those guys, it was miserable the things they had to deal with and nobody should have gone through that. But still, because

guys were able to get their music out. And artistically they were not stymied. Today I think it's a little different because I just feel like certain people are just not being allowed to express themselves because of a racial thing that really it wasn't. People want to think that it was that way back then with Duke and Louis Armstrong, but it wasn't.

MR: And they don't complain about it.

RS: No that generation, no they're very cool. I mean Buck — that's another irony is that the guys who lived through that, I mean Clark Terry you know had some terrible experiences. Buck Clayton like told me himself about one time when I think he was down south and I can't remember the exact story but like two carloads of these rednecks pulled up, and he thought that was it. He thought he was going to die. I mean he was in situations where his life was on the line just because of the color of his skin. And yet he bore no animus towards white people, he wouldn't generalize. And it disturbs me a little bit that now that things are better, there are a lot of opportunities, especially for younger black players, but I just kind of sense like they kind of thrive on — some of them, I don't want to generalize.

MR: I know what you're saying though.

RS: But they're being encouraged to feel that way I think. And look it's a phase, nothing lasts forever, the pendulum swings. Maybe because of the quirks of history things have to be this way right now, and we'll get to another side of it and everything. As I say, just as I see it, my frustration is okay, this is the time I happen to be living in. I look back on this time when Bix and Louis just loved each other and got along fine, when there was so much fraternal — I mean like Flip Phillips in these interviews that I've had with these guys, and I would ask them about this, they'd say no, they got along like brothers. Between the musicians it was like just totally cool.

MR: Well you said it about five times already, that the music was the focus. That the music brought them together I would guess.

RS: And I mean the thing that ultimately anything that divides, I mean that's another irony is that the whole thing about jazz is that it was kind of melting pot. What keeps it alive is all the influences coming in. When you get into this like racial purification it's kind of like Nazi talk. I mean that's the opposite of art, the opposite of something living, breathing. It's got to take in, to quote Jack Walrath, who was kind of like saying, he was like speaking against this idea of trying to form, saying that this is jazz, this isn't jazz, and that there should be this canon and a definition of what it is and what it isn't. He's saying look, the St. Louis Blues, from 1905, and the second strain is a tango. That says it right there. What is this purity stuff? There's nothing pure about it. It's anybody who feels that it belongs to them, and whatever they can bring — you know, European — I mean it's

Russia, they sent me a record, really good players. And I wrote back to them and I said this record is great but it sounds like it was made in New York. I said you know like there's so many interesting rhythmic things in the music from your part of the world, put some of that in there.

MR: Don't be ashamed, don't feel that you have to do—

RS: I mean yeah, don't copy, bring what you've got into it and it'll just make it stronger for everybody. And of course that happens. That will happen. But whether that gets focused on, I mean at this moment, it's like other things get more attention but that's just the way it is right now.

MR: Well I appreciate your eloquent thoughts on that subject. And I hope that in a few years we can do this again and we'll be able to talk about your recordings that focus on your concept.

RS: Well maybe the orchestra record will be out by then so—

MR: And whatever you're calling it at the time, that's cool. So on behalf of Hamilton College, I want to thank you.

RS: Well it's been a rare pleasure for me, because I don't get a chance to spout off that much. So thanks a lot, Monk.

MR: Okay.